Reflections on the Crofton formula

Work in progress

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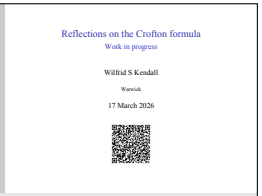
Abstract: The Crofton formula (the length of an arc can be estimated by the number of hits by a random line) is extremely important in modern-day microscopy. Exemplifying Stigler's (1980) law of eponymy (itself actually due to Robert Merton[1]), the formula is more properly described as the Cauchy-Crofton formula (announced in *Comptes Rendus* by Cauchy (1832)), and originates from the famous thought experiment on Buffon's baguettes. Together with the associated Poincaré kinematic formula, Crofton's formula can be proved by a simple intuitive visual argument in the case of polygonal curves. But the Crofton and Poincaré results actually hold for the far more general case of curves of finite total variation, in which context they require rather more technical proofs. I will report on progress I have made in deriving intuitive visual arguments for the general case.

Handout is on the web: use the `QR-code` or visit `wilfridskendall.github.io/talks/CroftonReflections-2026/CroftonReflections-handout.pdf`.

[1] Wikipedia:
"Everything of importance has been said before by somebody who did not discover it",
attributed to Alfred North Whitehead.

2026-03-17

Reflections on the Crofton formula



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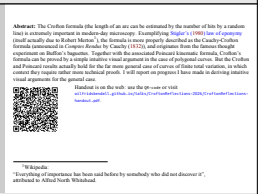

History (1)

Figure 1: Comte de Buffon

Georges Louis Leclerc (Comte de Buffon, 1707-1788): from a family of minor civil servants, inherited a fortune from godfather, moved to Paris in 1732, researched mathematics and then geology and botany, made a (hereditary) count in 1772, both empiricist ("Anglo-Saxon") and rationalist ("Gallic"). Seeking a motivation for probability other than gambling, Buffon introduced his famous *baguette example* (now "Buffon's needle": see Comte de Buffon, 1829; translation, Hey *et al.*, 2010).

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History (2)

Figure 2: Cauchy

Augustin-Louis Cauchy (1789-1857): French mathematician, engineer and physicist. He "is one of the 72 scientists whose name is inscribed on the first floor of the Eiffel Tower". Cauchy (1841; also 1832) used Buffon's ideas to show how to recover the length of a polygonal curve using *projections of the component segments on a random test line*.

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Figure 2: Cauchy

Cauchy was an utterly brilliant mathematician, but also a sad example of meanness (see treatment of Abel).

History (3)

Figure 3: Crofton

Morgan William Crofton (1826–1915): Anglo-Irish, Anglican Protestant upbringing but converted to Roman Catholism (connected with John Henry Newman), Professor of Mathematics at the Royal Military Academy at Woolwich, famous for his long article on probability in ninth edition of Encyclopaedia Britannica (Crofton, 1902; also Crofton, 1868), including *recovery of length of perimeter of a convex polygon using intersections with a random line*.

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Representative modern problems

The Cauchy-Crofton formula is fruitful in both applied and pure mathematics.

- (a) *Stereology:* impose random lattices on image sequence from microscope, count mean number of intersections with filaments of interest, deduce mean length of such a filament;
- (b) *Stochastic geometry:* consider mean number of intersections of curve with a *standard Poisson line process*, deduce length of curve;
- (c) *Differential geometry:* Chern's kinematic formula (for a very readable account, see Calegari, 2020!).

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Crofton's formula: a visual proof

A standard Poisson line process Π in the plane is produced by a unit intensity Poisson point process on $\mathbb{R} \times [0, \pi)$ using intensity measure $\frac{1}{2}\mathrm{d}r\,\mathrm{d}\theta$: here θ is slope and r is the signed distance from origin of the line corresponding to (r, θ). The number of intersections of Π with a unit segment has unit mean (*simple calculation*).

Let $f{:}[0, L] \to \mathbb{R}^2$ be a polygonal curve, and consider its mean number of intersections with Π. Divide trajectory of f into variable length segments s:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}\left[\#\left\{\mathrm{Image}(f) \cap \Pi\right\}\right] &= \sum_s \mathbb{E}\left[\#\left\{s \cap \Pi\right\}\right] \\ &= \sum_s \mathrm{length}(s) \end{aligned}$$

hence Crofton formula:
mean number of intersections with Π *equals length of curve*.

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The above proof generalizes to yield *Poincaré's kinematic formula*:

Replace Π by a standard Poisson process of random polygonal fibres.

Crofton and Poincaré results generalize to piece-wise C^1 curves by (slightly untidy) approximation.

Can we generalize further?

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Maximal generalization for Crofton formula

The components of Crofton's formula still make sense if $f:[0,L]\to\mathbb{R}^2$ is a continuous curve of finite length (Lipschitz(1)). How to prove this?

Options:

1. Use the *co-area formula* (Federer, 1969): Consider Lipschitz $p : M \to N$ between (eg) compact C^1 Riemannian manifolds of dimensions $m \geq n$. Then (adjusting exposition of Baddeley, 1983),
   - for almost all $x \in N$, the fibre $p^{-1}(x)$ is the union of $(m-n)$-dimensional C^1 submanifolds (up to a null-set for $(m-n)$-Hausdorff measure);
   - there is a measurable $J : M \to \mathbb{R}$ such that

$$\int_M f(z)J(z)\mathcal{H}^m(\mathrm{d}z) \quad = \quad \int_N \left(\int_{p^{-1}(x)} f(z)\mathcal{H}^{m-n}(\mathrm{d}z) \right) \mathcal{H}^n(\mathrm{d}x)\,.$$

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Baddeley (1983) describes how to use the co-area formula to derive not only Crofton formula for Lipschitz curves but also elegant generalizations which are very useful in stereology.

Figure 4: Sledge hammer

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- Ayari & Dubuc (1997) describe how to use the elegant exposition of total variation by Cesari (1958), together with a simple observation by Cauchy (1841; also 1832), which reduces the Crofton formula to the following *one-dimensional* version:

Banach's (1925) representation of total variation

For continuous $f{:}[0,L]\to\mathbb{R}$,

$$\text{Variation}\,(f) \quad = \quad \int_{\mathbb{R}} \#\,\{x \in [0,L] \;:\; f(x)=y\}\;\text{Leb}(\mathrm{d}y)\,, \qquad (1)$$

in the extended sense
(equality also holds when both sides of the equation are infinite).

- The right-hand side counts the mean number of intersections of the graph of f with a standard Poisson line process of *horizontal* lines (indexed by a unit intensity Poisson point process on the y-axis).

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Seeking a visual proof (1)

Objective: obtain a proof of Equation 1 that is as visual as possible.

Initial observation

1. **Infinite case:** infinite variation is straightforward (polygonal approximation lengths diverge).
2. **Symmetries:** If variation is finite, employ symmetry by
   (i) vertical shifts,
   (ii) non-linear change of x-scale
   to reduce to case in which $f(0)=0$ and f has weak derivative $\dot{f}$ with $|\dot{f}|=1$ almost everywhere on $[0,L]$
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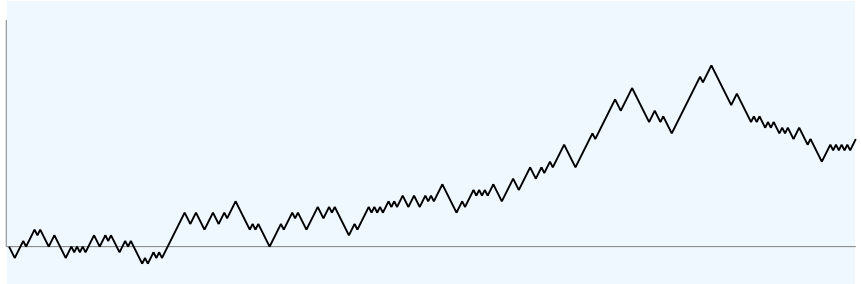

Figure 5: Random walk trajectory

3. An **unfold** *based at* $u<v\in[0,L]$ for positive *size* $2(f(u)-f(v))$:
   (i) reflects $f|_{[u,L]}$ in the horizontal line $y=f(u)$,
   (ii) then reflect resulting $\tilde{f}|_{[v,L]}$ in the horizontal line $y=f(v)$.
   - We illustrate this using a random walk trajectory (Figure 5).
   - **Maximal unfold** uses left-most $u<v$ realizing $\sup_{u\leq v}(f(u)-f(v))$.

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Equivalently, vertical reflection for $f|_{[u,v]}$ and vertical shift for $f|_{[v,L]}$.

Seeking a visual proof (3)

0. Original path $f=f_0$ with $u<v$ chosen to yield maximal unfold:

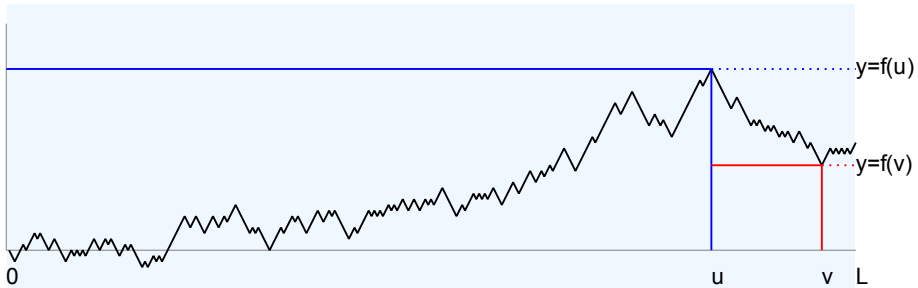

Figure 6: Maximal unfold based at $u<v$

Bear in mind the *size* of the unfold is $2(f(u)-f(v))$.

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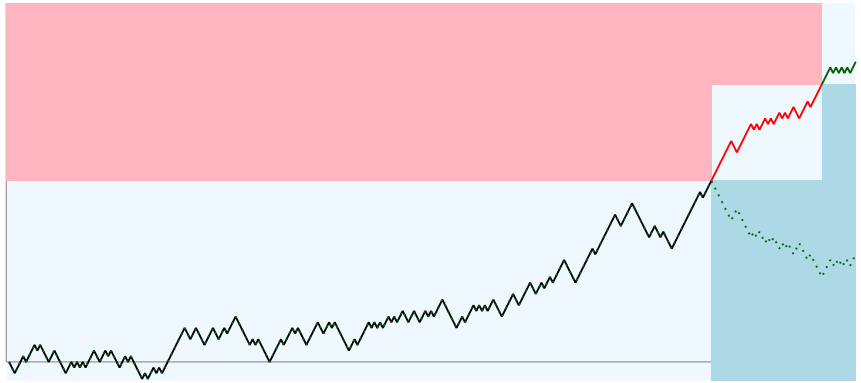
(note that the *unfolded* path f_1 does not enter the shaded regions):



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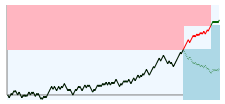

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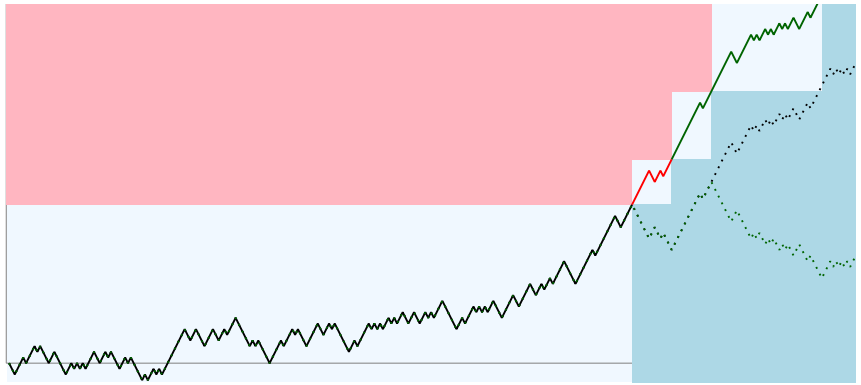
2. Second maximal unfolding generates f_2.
The previous shaded region is partially shifted and augmented.



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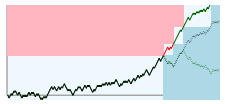

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3. Third maximal unfolding generates f_3.
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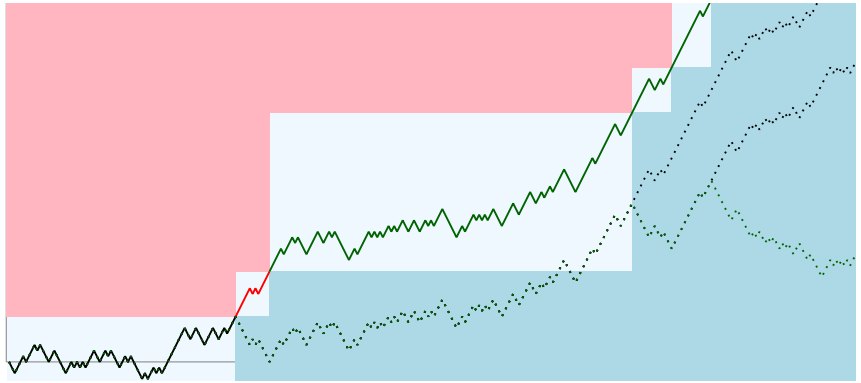

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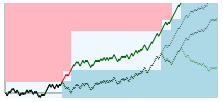

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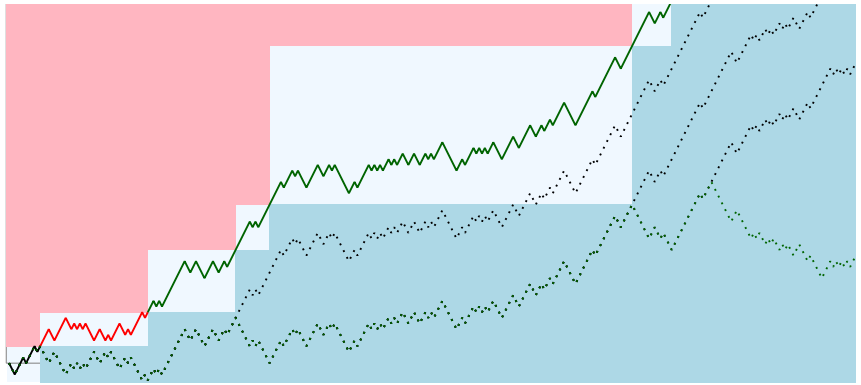
4. Fourth maximal unfolding generates f_4.
   The unfolding procedure increases f_n and makes it more monotonic.



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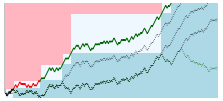
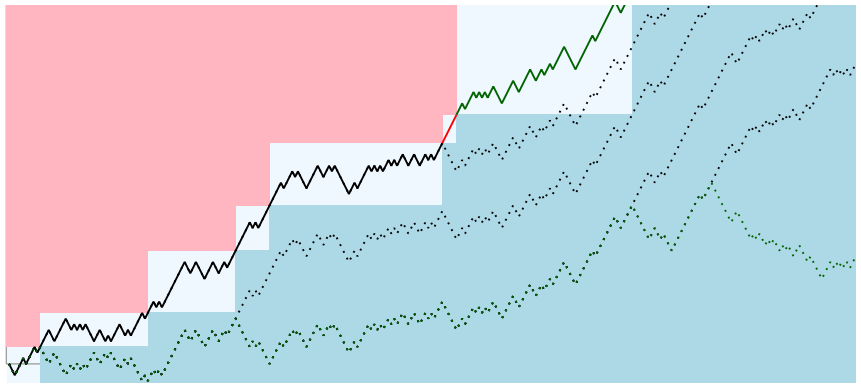


Figure 10: Effect of fourth unfold

5. Fifth maximal unfolding generates f_5.
   Here the unfolding procedure fragments a previous unfolding rectangle.



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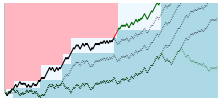

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Seeking a visual proof (considerations)

5. If $\sup_{u \le v} (f_k(u) - f_k(v)) = 0$ for some k then sequence ends at k.

- In this case f_k must be monotonic non-decreasing.
- In fact it must be monotonic **strictly** increasing (because the f_i all have $|\dot{f}_i| = 1$ almost everywhere and so can have no intervals of constancy):
- therefore $f_k(x) = x$ for all $x \in [0, L]$ and the Banach representation holds trivially for f_k.
- Invariance under vertical shifts and vertical reflections then implies the Banach representation then holds for the original f.
- (All this occurs precisely in the case of polygonal f!)

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6. If the sequence continues indefinitely then the sequence of $f_n(x)$ is non-decreasing for all $x \in [0, L]$;
   - the interval of reflection (u, v) of the nth unfold must be "nested" either to the left, or to the right, or inside the interval of reflection of each previous n^{th} unfold;
   - the f_n become progressively more and more "monotonic increasing" with a monotonic non-decreasing limit;
   - an unfold based at $u < v$ destroys one local maximum (at u) and one local minimum (at v), and preserves all other local maxima and minima (at most countably many, since f is continuous);
   - the sequence of unfold sizes is non-increasing and summable;
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7. **Final technical step:**

- Exploit nesting to generate a martingale argument that $\dot{f}_n$ converges in L^1-norm to the constant function 1.
- Thus $f_n(x) \to x$ as $n \to \infty$.
- Re-write the roots x of $f_n(x) = y$ to give information about the point patterns determined as roots x of $f(x) = y$:

$$\mathbb{I}\{\text{ there is } x \in [0, L] \ : \ f_n(x) = y\}$$

can be unravelled to produce partial counts of the point patterns

$$\{x \in [0, L] \ : \ f(x) = y\} \ .$$

The counts increase monotonically to

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Conclusion

1. Ayari & Dubuc (1997) explain how to derive Crofton formula using Cauchy (1832) idea: project curve onto line of angle θ, use Banach representation to determine variation for projected curve, integrate out θ (appealing to definition of variation using polygonal approximations).
2. Unravelling of roots x of $f_n(x) = y$ needs concise rigorous expression;
3. Alternate visual proof of Banach representation uses "monotonic runs" (peeling off successive layers of graph of f as viewed from the left);
4. It would be interesting to get a *direct* visual proof of the general Crofton formula (and – even more interesting – of the Poincaré kinematic formula).

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References I

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Project details

git version and branch

Version (branch):	v0.1.0.6 (`main`)
Committed by:	Wilfrid Kendall <W.S.Kendall@warwick.ac.uk>
Date:	Tue Mar 17 14:45:03 2026 +0000

Images

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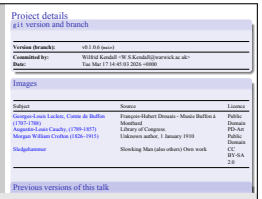
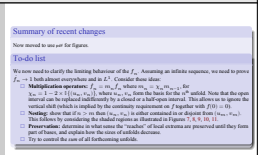
Previous versions of this talk



Summary of recent changes

Now moved to use `pdf` for figures.

To-do list

We now need to clarify the limiting behaviour of the f_n. Assuming an infinite sequence, we need to prove $\dot{f}_n \to 1$ both almost everywhere and in L^1. Consider these ideas:

- ☐ **Multiplication operators:** $\dot{f}_n = m_n \dot{f}_n$ where $m_n = \chi_n m_{n-1}$, for $\chi_n = 1 - 2 \times \mathbb{1}\{(u_n, v_n)\}$, where u_n, v_n form the basis for the nth unfold. Note that the open interval can be replaced indifferently by a closed or a half-open interval. This allows us to ignore the vertical shift (which is implied by the continuity requirement on f together with $f(0) = 0$).
- ☐ **Nesting:** show that if $n > m$ then (u_n, v_n) is either contained in or disjoint from (u_m, v_m). This follows by considering the shaded regions as illustrated in Figures 7, 8, 9, 10, 11.
- ☐ **Preservation:** determine in what sense the "reaches" of local extrema are preserved until they form part of bases, and explain how the sizes of unfolds decrease.
- ☐ Try to control the *sum* of all forthcoming unfolds.